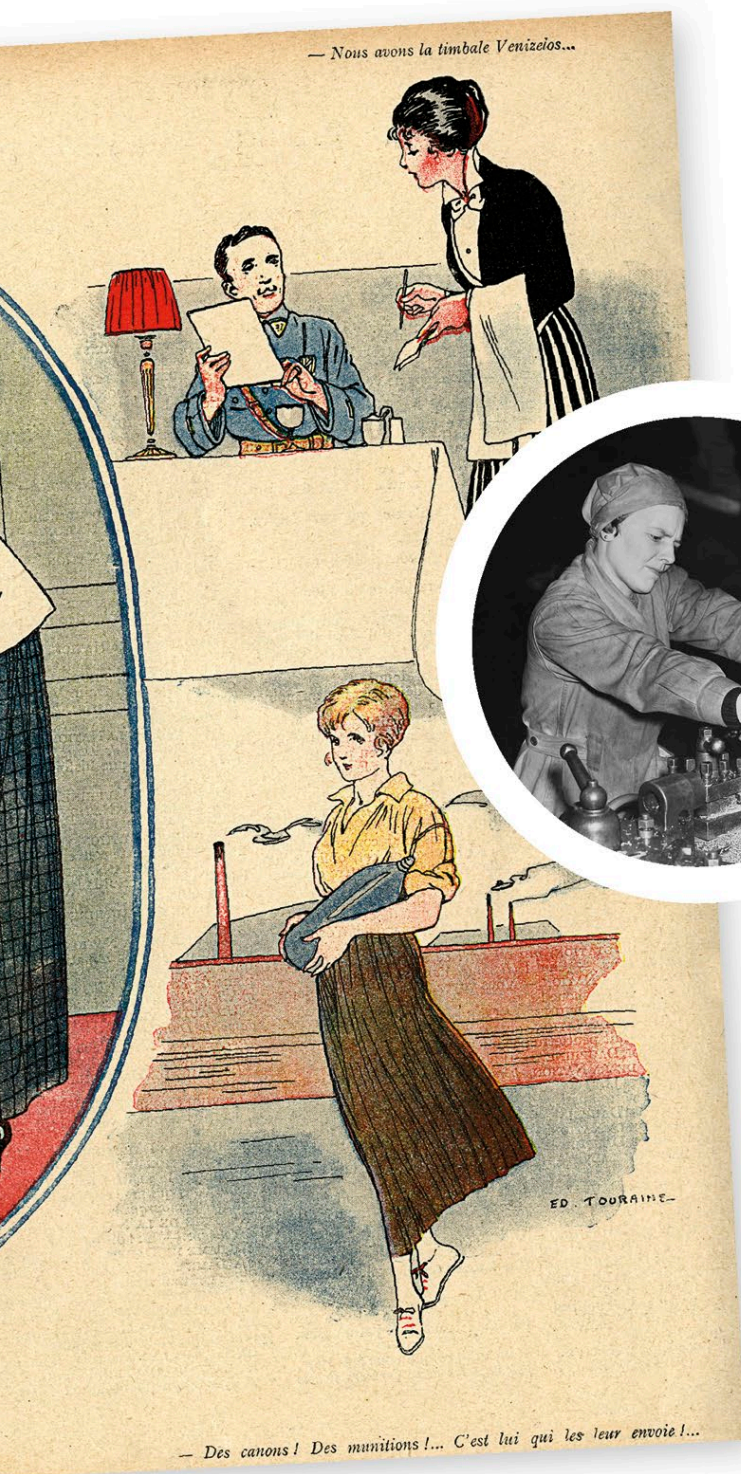




▼ Munitionettes

British women joined munitions factories to make the shells for the guns of World War I. By the end of the war, 80 percent of them were made by women.



"IF THE WOMEN IN THE FACTORIES STOPPED WORK ... THE ALLIES WOULD LOSE ..."

JOSEPH JOFFRE, FRENCH FIELD MARSHAL, 1914

to be disillusioned by the war or rising food prices and appealed to their sense of patriotism. With millions of men serving in the armed forces, women went into the workforce to replace them.

The war started in August, so women had to bring in the harvest. In France, 3,200,000 peasant women responded to the call to do the work of the three million farmers sent to the front lines. Even more important to the war effort was the work women did in industry, particularly in munitions factories. By 1918, virtually all women in unoccupied France were in paid employment, and in Germany, over 400,000 women worked in machine shops and 600,000 in ammunition plants, making up 55 percent of the industrial workforce. Contrary to popular belief, however, the number of working women in France and Germany did not drastically increase between 1914 and 1918—many women already in the workforce simply moved into more war-focused industries.

Dutch dancer known by her stage name, Mata Hari. She was recruited by France to spy for them in Belgium but was later convicted of being a German double agent and was executed by a French firing squad in 1917.

Women go to work

The greatest contribution by the vast majority of women in World War I was made on the home front. The need for women to continue to mobilize led to waves of government propaganda, which encouraged women not

3,200
Italian women
took over public
transport jobs to
become wartime
tram drivers.